Speak Ghana

Reconnect. Speak. Thrive.

Chapter 1

Nnɔmma – Twi Numbers

Akenkan, Mmere ne Nnɔmma wɔ Twi Kasa Mu!

Counting, Time, and Numbers in Daily Life

Nnɔmma Akenkan yɛ adeɛ fɛfɛ! Counting is a beautiful thing!

You've learned the alphabet, sounds, and greetings. Now it's time to count!

Numbers are essential for age, counting people, telling time, shopping, and many daily situations in Ghana. Without numbers, you cannot fully participate in daily conversations or transactions.

This chapter teaches you numbers 1–100, how to use them in real-life situations, and the special forms for counting people and telling time.

Why Numbers Matter in Ghana

- **At the market (Edwam):** "Ɛyɛ sɛn?" (How much is it?) and "Bɔ so" (Reduce the price)
- **In the trotro:** Paying your fare to the mate
- **Telling time:** "Dɔn ahe?" (What time is it?)
- **Talking about age:** "Wo mfe ahe?" (How old are you?)
- **Exchanging contacts:** "Ma me wo telefon nɔma" (Give me your phone number)

Pro Tip: Ghanaians appreciate when foreigners try to count in Twi. Even if your pronunciation isn't perfect, your effort shows respect and will often get you better prices!

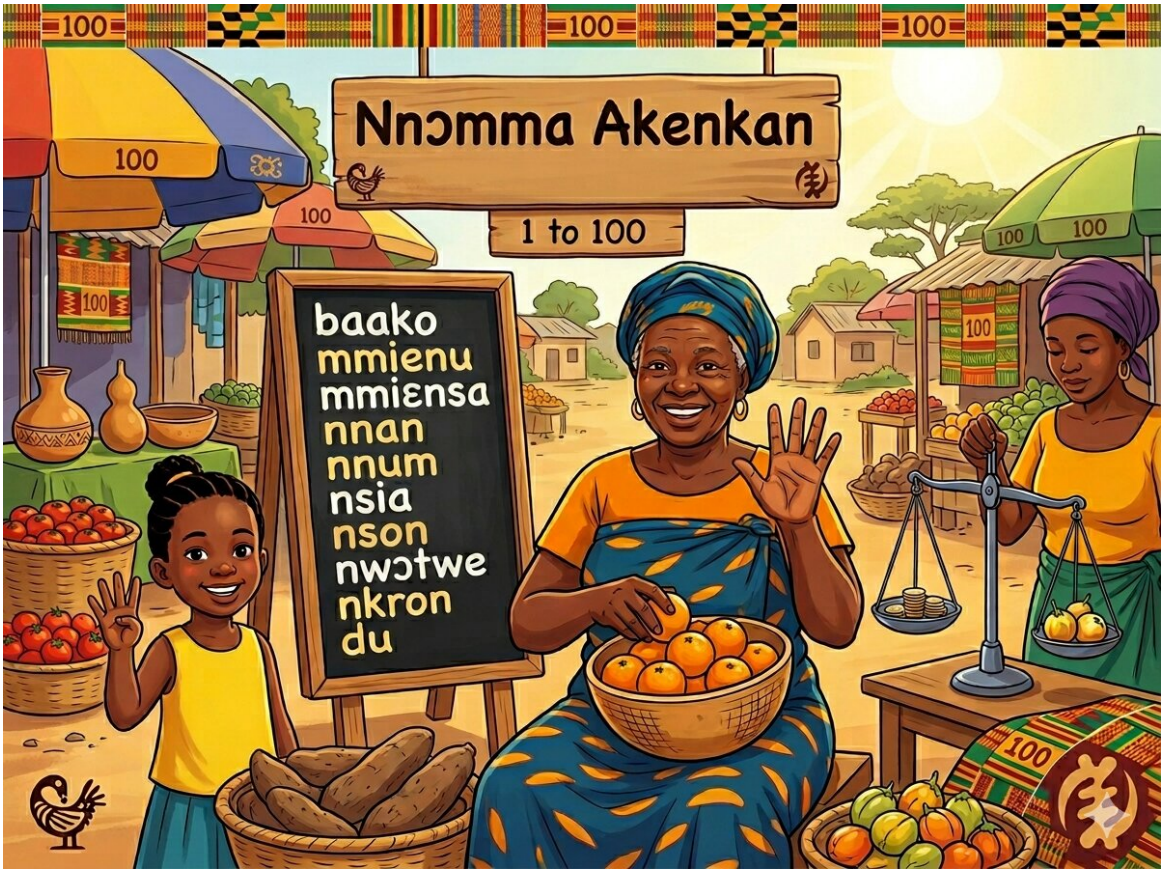

Figure 1.1: Nnɔmma Akenkan: Counting in Twi from 1 to 100

Section 1: Numbers – Nnɔmma (1–100)

Numbers 1–10 – The Foundation

Master these first – they are the building blocks for all other numbers.

Number	Twi	Pronunciation	Memory Trick
1	baako	baa-koh	”Baako” sounds like ”baker” – one baker
2	mmienu	mmee-eh-noo	Think ”two me’s” – mmienu
3	mmiɛnsa	mmee-ehn-sah	”Three men saw” – mmiɛnsa
4	nnan	n-nahn	”Four” ends with ”r” – ɛnan has ”n”
5	nnum	n-noom	”Num” sounds like ”number” – five is a number
6	nsia	n-see-ah	”Six see ya” – nsia
7	nson	n-sohn	”Seven son” – nson
8	nwɔtwe	n-woh-tweh	”Eight weight” – nwɔtwe
9	nkron	n-krohn	”Nine crown” – nkron
10	du	doo	”Ten do” – du

Daily Drill: Count from 1 to 10 every morning when you wake up. Say them aloud 5 times each. Do this for one week and you will never forget!

Numbers 11–19 – Building with ”Du”

For 11–19, simply add the unit number after ”du” (ten):

Number	Twi	Literal Meaning
11	du baako	ten and one
12	du mmienu	ten and two
13	du mmiɛnsa	ten and three
14	du ɛnan	ten and four
15	du ɛnum	ten and five
16	du nsia	ten and six
17	du nson	ten and seven
18	du nwɔtwe	ten and eight
19	du nkron	ten and nine

Note: ”Du ɛnum” (15) and ”du ɛnan” (14) use the full forms of 4 and 5. Some speakers say ”du nnum” for 15 – both are acceptable!

Tens – Aduo- Pattern

For 20–90, use ”aduo-” plus the unit:

Number	Twi	Pronunciation	Breakdown
20	aduonu	ah-doo-oh-noo	aduo- + nu (from ɛnum)
30	aduasa	ah-doo-ah-sah	aduo- + sa (from mmiɛnsa)
40	aduanan	ah-doo-ah-nahn	aduo- + nan (from ɛnan)
50	aduonum	ah-doo-oh-noom	aduo- + num (from ɛnum)
60	aduosia	ah-doo-oh-see-ah	aduo- + sia (from nsia)
70	aduoson	ah-doo-ohn-sohn	aduo- + son
80	aduonwɔtwe	ah-doo-ohn-woh-tweh	aduo- + nwɔtwe
90	aduonkron	ah-doo-ohn-krohn	aduo- + nkron
100	ɔha	oh-hah	New word

Numbers 21–99 – Combining Tens and Units

For numbers between tens, add the unit directly after the ten (no ”ne” needed):

Number	Twi	Pattern
21	aduonu baako	twenty + one
32	aduasa mmienu	thirty + two
45	aduanan enum	forty + five
58	aduonum nwɔtwe	fifty + eight
64	aduosia ɛnan	sixty + four
77	aduoson nson	seventy + seven
89	aduonwɔtwe nkron	eighty + nine
99	aduonkron nkron	ninety + nine

Complete Reference Table: Numbers 1–100

Num	Twi	Num	Twi	Num	Twi
1	baako	11	du baako	21	aduonu baako
2	mmienu	12	du mmienu	22	aduonu mmienu
3	mmiɛnsa	13	du mmiɛnsa	23	aduonu mmiɛnsa
4	nnan	14	du ɛnan	24	aduonu nnan
5	nnum	15	du ɛnum	25	aduonu nnum
6	nsia	16	du nsia	26	aduonu nsia
7	nson	17	du nson	27	aduonu nson
8	nwɔtwe	18	du nwɔtwe	28	aduonu nwɔtwe
9	nkron	19	du nkron	29	aduonu nkron
10	du	20	aduonu	30	aduasa

Num	Twi	Num	Twi	Num	Twi
31	aduasa baako	41	aduanan baako	51	aduonum baako
32	aduasa mmienu	42	aduanan mmienu	52	aduonum mmienu
33	aduasa mmiɛnsa	43	aduanan mmiɛnsa	53	aduonum mmiɛnsa
34	aduasa nnan	44	aduanan nnan	54	aduonum nnan
35	aduasa nnum	45	aduanan nnum	55	aduonum nnum
36	aduasa nsia	46	aduanan nsia	56	aduonum nsia
37	aduasa nson	47	aduanan nson	57	aduonum nson
38	aduasa nwɔtwe	48	aduanan nwɔtwe	58	aduonum nwɔtwe
39	aduasa nkron	49	aduanan nkron	59	aduonum nkron
40	aduanan	50	aduonum	60	aduosia

Num	Twi	Num	Twi	Num	Twi
61	aduosia baako	71	aduoson baako	81	aduonwɔtwe baako
62	aduosia mmienu	72	aduoson mmienu	82	aduonwɔtwe mmienu
63	aduosia mmiɛnsa	73	aduoson mmiɛnsa	83	aduonwɔtwe mmiɛnsa
64	aduosia nnan	74	aduoson nnan	84	aduonwɔtwe nnan
65	aduosia nnum	75	aduoson nnum	85	aduonwɔtwe nnum
66	aduosia nsia	76	aduoson nsia	86	aduonwɔtwe nsia
67	aduosia nson	77	aduoson nson	87	aduonwɔtwe nson
68	aduosia nwɔtwe	78	aduoson nwɔtwe	88	aduonwɔtwe nwɔtwe
69	aduosia nkron	79	aduoson nkron	89	aduonwɔtwe nkron
70	aduoson	80	aduonwɔtwe	90	aduonkron

Number	Twi
91	aduonkron baako
92	aduonkron mmienu
93	aduonkron mmiɛnsa
94	aduonkron nnan
95	aduonkron nnum
96	aduonkron nsia
97	aduonkron nson
98	aduonkron nwɔtwe
99	aduonkron nkron
100	ɔha

Numbers Practice Drill

Say these aloud until they flow naturally:

1–10: baako, mmienu, mmiɛnsa, nnan, nnum, nsia, nson, nwɔtwe, nkron, du
10–20: du, du baako, du mmienu, du mmiɛnsa ... du nkron, aduonu
20–30: aduonu, aduonu baako, aduonu mmienu ... aduonu nkron, aduasa
Tens: du, aduonu, aduasa, aduanan, aduonum, aduosia, aduoson, aduonwɔtwe, aduonkron, ɔha

Section 2: Using Numbers in Daily Life

Talking About Age – Mfeɛ

The most common use of numbers is talking about age.

Twi	English
Me wɔ mfeɛ aduonu nwɔtwe.	I am 28 years old.
Mewɔ mfeɛ aduonu baako.	I am 21 years old.
Ɔwɔ mfeɛ aduanan.	He/She is 40 years old.
Yɛwɔ mfeɛ aduonu mmiɛnsa.	We are 23 years old.
Wɔwɔ mfeɛ aduonum.	They are 50 years old.

Question Forms:

- **Woadi mfeɛ sɛn?** (How old are you? – lit. You have eaten years how many?)
- **Woadi mfeɛ sɛn?** (How many years have you lived? – alternative)
- **Ɔwɔ mfeɛ sɛn?** (How old is he/she?)

Cultural Note: Some older Ghanaians may not know their exact birth year, or may consider it impolite to ask directly. If someone hesitates, don't push. You can ask "Wɔwoo wo berɛ bɛn?" (When were you born?) instead.

Cultural Tip: When asking an elder their age, show respect by adding "agya" (sir) or "ɛna" (ma): "Agya, woadi mfeɛ sɛn?"

Counting People – Nnipa

When counting people, place the number after "nnipa":

Twi	Meaning
nnipa baako	one person
nnipa baanu	two people
nnipa baasa	three people
nnipa baanan	four people
nnipa baanum	five people
nnipa nsia	six people
nnipa nson	seven people
nnipa nwɔtwe	eight people
nnipa nkron	nine people
nnipa du	ten people

Special Note: When counting people, numbers 2–5 change form:

- mmienu (2) → baanu
- mmiɛnsa (3) → baasa
- nnan (4) → baanan
- nnum (5) → baanum

For numbers 6–10, use the regular forms (nsia, nson, nwɔtwe, nkron, du).

Counting Things – Nneɛma

For objects, use the number directly after the noun with no special changes:

Twi	Meaning
aburoo baako	one orange
aburoo mmienu	two oranges
cedi du	ten cedis (money)
nwoma mmiɛnsa	three books
bɔlo nnum	five balls

Phone Numbers and Money

- **Phone number:** ”Me phone nɔmba yɛ...” (My phone number is...)
- **Asking for a number:** ”Ma me wo telefon nɔma” (Give me your phone number)
- **Price:** ”Ɛyɛ sika ahe?” (How much money is it?)
- **Response:** ”Ɛyɛ sika aduonu” (It’s 20 cedis)

Asking ”How Much?” – Shopping Phrases

Twi	English
Ɛyɛ sɛn?	How much is it?
Wotɔn no sɛn?	How do you sell it?
Ɛyɛ sika ahe?	How much money?
Ma me baako.	Give me one.
Bo so.	Reduce the price.

Sample Market Dialogue

Edwam Nkɔmmɔ – Market Talk

Buyer: Maakye! Ɛyɛ sɛn?
Seller: Maakye! Ɛyɛ Cedi aduonu.
Buyer: Te bo no so. Mɛtɔ baako.
Seller: Yoo. Ma me Cedi du nwɔtwe.
Buyer: Medaase!
Seller: Mepa wo kyɛw, bra bio!

Translation:

Buyer: Good morning! How much is it?
Seller: Good morning! It’s 20 Cedis.
Buyer: Reduce it. I will buy one.
Seller: OK. Give me 18 Cedis.
Buyer: Thank you!
Seller: Please, come again!

Section 3: Telling Time – Berɛ

Ghanaian time is often more flexible and approximate than Western time. People may say ”I’ll come in the evening” rather than ”I’ll come at 7:30 PM.”

Hours of the Day

Twi	English
anɔpa	morning (dawn until around 10 AM)
awia	daytime / late morning
awia mpae mu	midday / noon (around 12 PM)
anwummerɛ	evening (from late afternoon until dark)
anadwo	night (after dark)
ahemadakye	midnight

Telling Clock Time – Dɔn

The word for ”hour” or ”o’clock” is **dɔn**.

Time	Twi	Meaning
1:00	Dɔn baako	Hour one
2:00	Dɔn mmienu	Hour two
3:00	Dɔn mmiɛnsa	Hour three
4:00	Dɔn nnan	Hour four
5:00	Dɔn nnum	Hour five
6:00	Dɔn nsia	Hour six
7:00	Dɔn nson	Hour seven
8:00	Dɔn nwɔtwe	Hour eight
9:00	Dɔn nkron	Hour nine
10:00	Dɔn du	Hour ten
11:00	Dɔn du baako	Hour eleven
12:00	Dɔn du mmienu	Hour twelve

Asking and Telling Time

Twi	English
Dɔn ahe?	What time is it?
Dɔn ahe na ɛyɛ?	What time is it? (formal)
Ɛyɛ dɔn mmienu.	It is 2 o’clock.
Mereba dɔn du.	I am coming at 10 o’clock.
Yɛbɛhyia dɔn nsia.	We will meet at 6 o’clock.

Adding time of day:

- Dɔn nnan anɔpa – 4 AM (4 o’clock in the morning)
- Dɔn du awia – 10 AM (10 o’clock in the daytime)
- Dɔn mmienu anwummerɛ – 2 PM (2 o’clock in the evening)
- Dɔn nkron anadwo – 9 PM (9 o’clock at night)

Section 4: Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Mistake:** Saying ”du du” for 20
  Fix: 20 is ”Aduonu” – a special word!
- **Mistake:** Forgetting the nasal ’n’ in numbers 4–9
  Fix: Hum before saying Nnan, Nnum, Nsia, Nson, Nwɔtwe, Nkron
- **Mistake:** Using normal numbers for people 2–5
  Fix: For 2–5 people, use Baanu, Baasa, Baanan, Baanum
- **Mistake:** Adding ”ne” for numbers 21–99
  Fix: Say ”Aduonu baako” (21), not ”Aduonu ne baako”
- **Mistake:** Mispronouncing the ’w’ in Nwɔtwe (8)
  Fix: Practice the ’nw’ blend – it’s one sound, not two separate letters
- **Mistake:** Confusing 4 (nnan) and 100 (ɔha)
  Fix: 4 is ”n-nahn”, 100 is ”oh-hah” – very different sounds!

Section 5: Quick Reference Card

Nkontaabuo Mu Nnɔma – Numbers at a Glance

1–10:	baako, mmienu, mmiɛnsa, nnan, nnum, nsia, nson, nwɔtwe, nkron, du
11–19:	du + number (du baako, du mmienu...)
20:	aduonu (not ”du du”!)
21–99:	ten + unit (aduonu baako, aduasa mmienu...)
30:	aduasa
40:	aduanan
50:	aduonum
60:	aduosia
70:	aduoson
80:	aduonwɔtwe
90:	aduonkron
100:	ɔha

For people (2–5): baanu, baasa, baanan, baanum

Shopping: ”Ɛyɛ sɛn?” (How much?) • ”Bo so” (Reduce it)

Time: ”Dɔn ahe?” (What time?) • ”Dɔn baako anɔpa” (1 AM)

Chapter 3 Summary – What You’ve Learned

- Numbers 1–10 (the foundation – say them daily!)
- Numbers 11–19 (du + pattern)
- Numbers 20–90 (aduo- pattern)
- Numbers 21–99 (ten + unit, no ”ne” needed!)
- How to talk about age (Me wɔ mfeɛ...)
- How to count people (special forms for 2–5)
- How to count things (no special changes)
- How to ask ”How much?” (Ɛyɛ sɛn?)
- Market dialogue for shopping
- Telling time (Dɔn + number + time of day)
- Phone numbers and prices
- Common mistakes and how to avoid them

Kɔ so kan! – Keep counting!
Numbers are everywhere. Practice counting everything you see – mangoes, Cedis, people, minutes. Soon numbers will feel as natural as breathing!
Coming up in Chapter 4: Forming Simple Sentences

Onua, wo atu mpɔn!, Brother/Sister, you have progressed!
Yɛbɛkɔ so wɔ Chapter 4!

Speak Ghana Language School
www.speakghana.org
WhatsApp: +233 55 226 3323
info@speakghana.org

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